Bad news quickly spread across the capital city as chiefs, generals and soldiers began straggling in, grabbing what they could of their possessions and fleeing the city with their families. Within hours, the royal family fled with hundreds of elephants ‘laden with treasures in gold, diamonds, and precious stones’. Others took the few remaining ox-carts that had not been taken to the war. The citizens began realizing that this was not merely a defeat but a catastrophe. For over two hundred years, no enemy had penetrated the walls of Vijayanagar and now they were at the unguarded gates. Some buried their treasures, many fled, others waited hoping for the best.

As news of the defeat spread, the depopulating city first fell prey to nearby tribes, such as the Brinjaris, Lambadis, Kurubas and other nomadic groups, who looted its markets. One wonders what sort of relations Vijayanagar had fostered with them to invite this opportunism. The enemy troops then arrived to plunder the city, and they apparently did so for five or six months, leaving it ruined and desolate. Little would survive of Vijayangar’s palaces and other residences; built using wooden pillars and beams, they were either easily burnt down or otherwise crumbled over time.

Scholars disagree about what exactly happened. On the one hand, historians Hermann Kulke and Dietmar Rothermund write, ‘The victors destroyed Vijayanagar, thus taking revenge for Krishnadevaraya’s devastation of the old Bahmani capital of Gulbarga in 1520. There are few comparable instances in history of such a sudden defeat and of such a wanton destruction of a large imperial capital: Vijayanagar was even more thoroughly sacked than was Delhi by Timur’s army.’[41] On the other hand, historian John Keay writes, ‘Despite colourful [later] descriptions of a five-month sack, wholesale slaughter, savage iconoclasm and such remorseless demolition that “nothing now remains but a heap of ruins”, the impression these “ruins” convey is less of wilful destruction and more of neglect, plus some random treasure-hunting and much casual pillage of building materials.’ He accurately points out, ‘Temples, the bigot’s prime target, prove to be the least damaged structures; and in many of them the statuary, so invitingly vulnerable, remains miraculously intact.’[42] Some of these sculptures still stand among the ruins, while many others are in the ASI